8

CULTURES OF PLURALISM IN INDIA'S SOFT POWER STRATEGY

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This chapter examines how the Indian government has used public diplomacy to promote a pluralist image driven by a dual strategic objective: to compensate for the rising military and economic asymmetry with China and, at the same time, to reassure its smaller neighbours who are concerned about India's rise. Particularly in its own neighbourhood, including South and Southeast Asia, India has faced a dilemma while dealing with an increasingly influential and assertive China. Unwilling to bandwagon cooperatively with Beijing's growing hard power, India has, however, also been unable to adopt a balancing posture. Several of India's neighbours, including Sri Lanka and Nepal, privilege closer relations with China and are concerned that supporting India's balancing behaviour could curtail critical support from Beijing. Particularly under the leadership of Prime Minister Modi since 2014, India has thus developed a middle path by placing greater emphasis on culture in its neighbourhood policy. This is one among several of its asymmetric strategies to respond to the rise of China in